

Toward a Behavior Analysis of Complex Language for Children with Autism: Evaluating the Relationship between PEAK and the VB-MAPP

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Published online: 15 November 2014
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Abstract The purpose of the present study was to evaluate the relationship between two behavioral language assessments that are currently used to evaluate the verbal repertoires of individuals with autism. The assessments include *Promoting the Emergence of Advanced Knowledge Relational Training System* (PEAK) and the *Verbal Behavior Milestones Assessment and Placement Program* (VB-MAPP). Forty students with autism were administered each of the assessments. The results suggest that there was a strong correlation between PEAK total scores and the VB-MAPP ($r=0.8266$, $p<0.0001$), and that a logarithmic regression model provided a good fit for the data ($R^2=0.9598$). Also, a ceiling effect was observed for the VB-MAPP around a PEAK total score of 138 of 368, suggesting that PEAK may provide a more robust measure of advanced language skills in individuals with autism. The utility of these findings for behavioral clinicians and researchers are discussed.

Keywords PEAK · VB-MAPP · Complex verbal behavior · Language · Autism

Autism is a developmental disability that is marked by severe deficits in language, social behaviors, and response variability (Howlin 1997). These deficits can have a profound impact on the autonomy and habilitation of individuals with autism and their families, as well as a salient economic impact on society (Buescher et al. 2014). Blumberg et al. (2013) report that anywhere from 1 in 86 to 1 in 50 individuals now have an autism spectrum disorder, a 289.5 % increase over the past 12 years (Boyle et al. 2011). Moreover, data suggest that 1 in 4 individuals with an autism spectrum disorder do not display vocal language (Autism and Inc 2014), and those who do often demonstrate delays in their language development relative to typically developing peers

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